CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SOLAR INSTALLER IN THE AI ERA

Part roofer, part electrician's right hand, working on the energy transition one rooftop at a time — while the sun does the marketing.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K for experienced installers and crew leads, enterable in 1–6 months with no license required for panel installation itself. The catch: it's roofing-grade physical work, and the industry's booms and policy swings run straight through your schedule. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

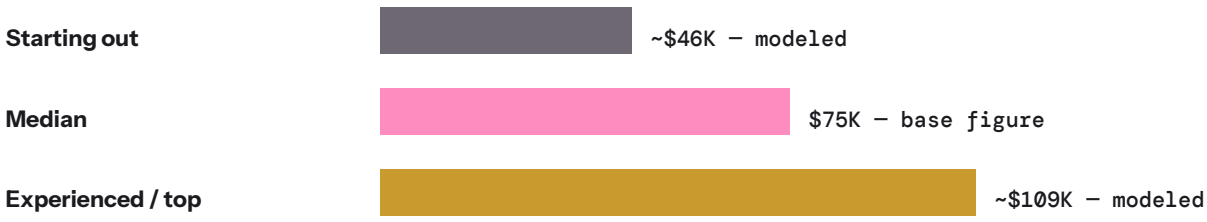
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: rooftops keep getting panels, batteries and EV chargers, and installation is irreducibly local, physical work.
- Bites because: demand rides incentives and interest rates — solar companies hire fast and fold fast.
- AI angle: minimal on the roof. Design and permitting software is excellent; racking, wiring and weatherproofing on real roofs is a crew of humans.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Solar Installer is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SOLAR INSTALLER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Mount racking systems to roofs, true and sealed, then set and secure panels
- ✓ Run conduit and DC wiring to inverters, and assist the electrician with tie-ins
- ✓ Install batteries and monitoring gear; test and commission the system
- ✓ Work roofs safely: harnesses, ladders, material hoisting, weather calls

Think: a roofer who leaves a power plant behind on every job.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Satellite roof design, shade analysis, automated permitting documents — the office is fully software now. The anchor bolt either hits the rafter and seals, or it doesn't, and a person is holding the drill.	Roof judgment: old decking, weird pitches, flashing that will actually last, and safe calls on wind and heat. Plus the electrical tie-in side, which is licensed-electrician territory installers grow toward.

⚠ **Know the split: installers mount and wire arrays, but final electrical connections usually belong to licensed electricians — career climbers treat solar as a bridge toward electrical licensing, not a ceiling. And vet employers hard; this industry has fly-by-night in its DNA.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Outdoor work with a visible, feel-good product ✓ Crews are young and the ladder to crew lead is short ✓ Skills transfer straight into roofing and electrical — two big trades	✗ Roof heat doubles in summer; panels are heavy and awkward ✗ Layoffs follow policy news and company cash flow ✗ Travel to sites can eat your mornings

Good fit? You're fit, height-comfortable, and like working in a small crew with a finished system to show at day's end.
Bad fit? You need a stable, single-employer decade, or heights and heat rule you out — solar is roofing's cousin, with wiring.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — INSTALLER AT A SOLAR COMPANY	DOOR B — ELECTRICAL APPRENTICE WITH SOLAR FOCUS

Solar companies hire installers with construction or roofing aptitude and train their systems on the job. You'll start on racking and modules, then wiring and commissioning — inside 1–6 months you're a real crew member, and crew lead is a realistic near-term step.	Enter through electrical: apprentice with a solar/electrical contractor so your hours count toward an electrician license while you install arrays. Slower to the roof, far stronger destination — the license is the industry's high ground.

Smart move: Get NABCEP certification as you gain experience — it's the industry's recognized credential and the one crew leads and designers are screened by. Pair it with battery/storage training; storage is where the margins moved.
Where you land after: Installer → crew lead → site supervisor or designer; or across into licensed electrician — the strongest exit in the industry.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET HIRED	LEARN THE	LEARN THE	COMMISSION AND	CERTIFY (NABCEP)	CLIMB: LEAD,

STEP 1 — Get hired on a crew

FREE · WEEK 1

- Apply to solar installers and solar-electric contractors; roofing or construction experience counts heavily.
- Ask about their install volume and how long crews have been with them — stability signals in a swingy industry.

STEP 2 — Learn the roof system

MONTHS 1-3

- Racking, flashing, sealing, layout — the roofing half of the craft, done to last decades.
- Fall protection as religion: harnesses, anchors, and the discipline to use them tired.

STEP 3 — Learn the electrical side

MONTHS 2-6

- DC wiring, conduit, inverters, disconnects — and the line where installer work ends and licensed work begins.
- Read one-line diagrams until systems make sense as systems, not just panels.

STEP 4 — Commission and troubleshoot

ONGOING

- Testing, monitoring setup, and finding the string that's underperforming.
- Service calls teach failure modes that installs never show you.

STEP 5 — Certify (NABCEP) EXAM + FEES

- NABCEP PV Installation Professional or associate credentials are the field's standard proof.
- Certification separates career installers from seasonal hands when work tightens.

STEP 6 — Climb: lead, design, or license YEAR 1+

- Crew lead and site supervision reward installers who can plan a roof day.
- Or convert experience into electrical apprenticeship hours and aim at the license — the top of this industry.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: list solar companies hiring installers; note which are also electrical contractors.
- Days 1–30: on a crew — racking, modules, roof safety until it's muscle memory.
- Days 31–60: wiring and inverter work under supervision; study system diagrams at night.
- Days 61–90: first commissioning reps; register for NABCEP associate-level prep if eligible.
- Day 90: a real installer with the fork mapped — crew lead, design, or electrical license.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **THE SUN SHOWS UP DAILY. SO DO YOU.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.